



YUVRAJ SINGH'S SIX SIXES GAVE A DECISIVE DIRECTION TO OUR CAMPAIGN

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Robin Uthappa

Being part of a remarkable triumph was a true honour. Despite the heartbreaking early exit from the 2007 ICC ODI World Cup, we refused to let it break our spirit. We played the Natwest Series in England, and though we lost 3-4, it was a testament to our resilience. My personal comeback at The Oval, where MS (Dhoni) and I added 60 runs for the sixth wicket, was a moment of redemption. During this high-scoring

match, I secured the winning run with just two balls remaining, hitting a four off Stuart Broad.

The confidence I gained from the win at The Oval was crucial in helping me stay mentally strong. Just five days after we played the final ODI in England at Lord's, we were lining up against Scotland at Durban.

Unfortunately, the game was washed out due to rain. Despite the novelty of the T20 format, our team was committed to adapting and

excelling. We meticulously practised the bowl-out. This preparation, which turned out to be a stroke of genius, clearly demonstrated our dedication and hard work.

The tied match against Pakistan was a turning point for us. Pakistan seemed to have the upper hand, but then Misbah-ul-Haq's run-out kept us in the game. I was proud of my half-century, but more than my batting, I was thrilled to have contributed with fielding and some bowling. It was a victory that we truly earned.

I was tasked with being part of the bowl-out group, a nerve-wracking moment for any player. I was third to hit the stumps after Viru (Sehwag) and Bhajju (Harbhajan). Pakistan missed all their three attempts (Yasir Arafat, Umar Gul, and Shahid Afridi). The loss against New Zealand in Johannesburg was a setback, but it didn't deter us. When we returned to Durban, we hit back through Yuvi (Yuvraj Singh) against England.

Yuvi's dazzling knock was a game-changer. Sitting in the dugout, I could hear the spat between Yuvi and Andrew Flintoff. Poor Stuart Broad suffered Yuvi's wrath. His six sixes in an over gave a decisive direction to our campaign. There was no stopping as we tamed South Africa and Australia for another clash with Pakistan in the final. We knew the challenge — defending 157 against a good batting lineup — would require us to be at our best. RP Singh gave us a splendid start with two wickets, and then Joginder Sharma joined the act. It was a tense match, with both teams giving their all. It worked well for us when Irfan (Pathan) dented Pakistan's hopes. But we had to reckon with Misbah.

They needed 13 runs from Joginder's last over. The first ball went over my head at long-on for a six. I was praying. The next ball, I saw the ball go up to Sreesanth. When he took the catch, I had reached mid-on. That gave me a chance to grab a stump as a souvenir.

As told to Vijay Lokapally